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Policy spaces, mobile discourses, and the definition of educated identities

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The aim of this article is to analyse the circulation of discourse in the global educational field and its relation to local-specific education policies and practices. The first section examines the logic of networks and relates it to the specificities of the networks of interaction that, it is argued, constitute ‘global policy spaces’ in education. It is then suggested that the structural attributes and politics of ‘global policy spaces’ influence the type of discourses produced in this space. The second and third sections will analyse how the mobile discourses that are produced and reproduced in these networks are transformed as they move into the space of places (the state and institutions that are attached to a territory). The main argument is that as discourses that define an educated identity for the information age move from global space to the state and to practice-based institutions these discourses change their meaning and their practical effects.

Introduction

What does it mean to be an educated person? As comparativists our immediate reaction to this question is a relativist one: it depends where you locate the question in time and space. Thus, a classical way to approach the question about educated identities is to relate a given ‘culture’ to a specific definition of ‘good knowledge’ and, in many cases, to its embodiment in ‘the curriculum’. In this perspective, cultural space is defined in terms of geopolitical borders. So, Encyclopaedism has French and German versions, Essentialism is British and so on. As each of these versions of educated identities moves to other parts of the world a transformation takes place. The influence of French Encyclopaedism in Argentina and Brazil is quite obvious. But in each of these countries the French influences have been interpreted differently, resulting in specific definitions of educated identities. Differences in certain contextual ‘factors’ (using Hans’ (1958) vocabulary) such as culture, political systems, economic circumstances, explain the changes that take place as certain ideas about what it means to be an educated person move across international borders. Again, cultural and political space is interpreted in terms of geopolitical international borders, which define the process of recontextualisation that takes place as ideas move.

This article offers another perspective for analysing the movement of ideas about what it means to be an educated person and, most importantly, the transformation of these ideas as they move between contexts. This perspective is based on Castells’ (2000a) notion of space, which distinguishes between a space of flows (organised around networks of interaction without the need for territorial contiguity) and a space

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of places (where social interaction is attached to a locale). Three contexts will be considered: global educational space, the state, and practice in schools.

The main argument is that as discourses that define an educated identity for the information age move from global space to the state and to practice-based institutions these discourses change their meaning and their practical effects. The article does not assume that this trajectory of discourse (from the global through the state and, later, to institutions) is the only possible form of interaction between these contexts. There are global networks of schools that exchange information without the involvement of the state, and there are states that are impermeable to certain global influences. In that sense the statements that follow do not pretend to comprise the totality of possible interactions between these contexts. Rather they offer a series of exploratory propositions about how the politics and structural attributes of each of these three contexts affect the processes of recontextualisation that take place as global discourses influence education policies and practices.

The article is divided into three parts. The first section will analyse the logic of networks and relate it to the specificities of the networks of interaction that, it will be argued, constitute global educational space. The second section will analyse how the networks analysed before, and the mobile discourses that are produced and reproduced in these networks, relate to the state. Finally, the article will analyse how these discourses relate to practice in schools that are attached to a territory. Not all space is organised around the space of flows. Most people live, work, study and construct their meaning around places. Furthermore, identities are often built on the basis of sharing historical experience in a given territory. Similarly, even though educated identities in different places have been influenced by transnationally disseminated educational discourses, the definition of these identities is also based on historical experience in a given territory.

However, in global educational space a notion of what it means to be 'educated for the information age' has been defined and advocated in most educational systems. Although analysing the whole definition of this educated identity exceeds the possibilities of this article, two specific components of this educated identity will be examined by trying to grasp the logic that was used in global educational space to promote these principles, and how this logic is transformed as it is localised in the state and in schools. Thus, the idea that schools should be aimed at the 'development of competencies' and the notion that individuals should be educated to 'respect diversity' will be used to exemplify how educational discourse is transformed in each of the three contexts that will be analysed.

Global policy spaces and the movement of educational discourses

The point of departure in this section is constituted by a series of questions that, it is argued, define the intellectual challenge of understanding the movement of educational discourse: What is it that moves? Where does it move from? Where does it move to? Why does it move? How does it move? Is it transformed as it moves? How is it transformed? Why is it transformed?

The point of arrival (or hopefully just a stopover) is constituted by a series of theoretical propositions that will be aimed at contributing to a better understanding of the processes through which educational discourse is produced, reproduced, moved, and transformed in the global educational field. The journey will start by reflecting upon a possible way to define educational space. Then, an attempt will be made to describe

some of the most salient characteristics of what I shall call 'global policy spaces', and finally, this section will analyse how the politics and structural attributes of global policy spaces affect the ways in which educational discourse is transformed in these contexts.

The social sciences have often assumed that 'nation states' are the logical unit to use when classifying and dividing social space and, thus, have many times taken for granted the nation state as a unit of analysis. The concept of 'methodological nationalism' is used to denote this assumption (Wimmer and Glick Schiller 2002; Dale 2005). Even analyses of phenomena that take place beyond the realms of nation states have fallen in to the trap.

[T]he concepts of 'transnational' (literally across nations) and 'international' (literally between nations) commonly used in comparative education, both assume a 'national' level or basis of activity; their focus is what happens across and between nations. By contrast, the concept of supranational (literally above nations) denotes a separate, distinct and non-reducible level or scale of activity from the national (Dale 2005, 125).

Furthermore, even though the term 'supranational' has the advantages that Dale mentions above, the definition of a given space as being 'supranational' is still based on a perspective that takes the nation state as its reference to construe that space.

An option to classify space which avoids the nation state as its main spatial reference is the distinction between a space of flows and a space of places suggested by Castells (2000a). There is a difference between the notions of 'space' and 'place', although they are generally used as being more or less synonyms. 'Place' refers to the physical setting of social activity as situated geographically (Giddens 1990). 'Space' is the material support of time-sharing social practices (Castells 2000a). Traditionally, time-sharing social practices could only occur between people that were situated in the same place. Thus space was attached to place. In current times, it is quite obvious that social interaction does not need territorial contiguity and, consequently, space is dislocated from place – a process that is linked to modernity and has been steadily intensified by technological developments (Giddens 1990). In this context, the space of flows can be defined as 'the material arrangements that allow for simultaneity of social practices without territorial contiguity' (Castells 2000b, 19). Meanwhile, the space of places is the site of social interaction that is overall attached to a given territory.

One of the greater challenges in the social sciences in current times is to understand the relation between these two spatial logics. In education (at least when analysing formal schooling), understanding this relation is fundamental because much of the agenda-setting in education is defined in the space of flows with the aim of influencing place-based education policies and school practices.

The space of flows in education is constituted by a series of networks of interaction and exchange of information in which global discourses about education are produced and reproduced. Information technologies are the main material support that provides the infrastructure for the networks of interaction that constitute the space of flows. But the nodes of these dislocated networks are real institutions and individuals. Furthermore, the space of flows also has its territorial centres (for example, Wall Street and London in global financial networks, and Paris and Washington in networks of international agencies) (Castells 2000a).

So, the main intellectual and political problem for comparative education is not information technologies, but rather to understand how the politics and structural

attributes of the networks that constitute global educational space shape the type of discourses that are produced and reproduced in this space, influencing territorially bound education policy in different parts of the world.

According to Castells (2000c) networks have a particular logic that pervades the social processes and interactions that are organised around them. In addition, the interactions and goals of each specific network will specify this logic. In other words, there is a logic related by definition to all networks as a form of social organisation, but each network also has its own logic in which it functions. In the remaining part of this section I will analyse the logic of networks and relate it to the specificities of the networks of interaction that, it will be argued, constitute global educational space.

Networks as social forms are value-free or neutral. Like an automaton, they process the goals they are programmed to perform, while fighting off all goals which contradict the programmed one. It is social actors who define the goals of the network, and there can be political struggles about this definition. However, once the network is programmed it imposes its logic, goals and rules on all social actors that participate. Different networks may communicate only if they have shared goals (Castells 2000c).

In principle, the networks that constitute global educational space can have different goals. Given the specific theme of this article the analysis is centred on those networks whose goal could be defined as the search for solutions to the universal problem of education, and the advocacy of these solutions in place-based educational systems. It is these networks that constitute what I shall call a 'global policy space'.

Different types of actors, such as international agencies, consultants, universities, corporations, development agencies, regional blocks, and NGOs participate in this interaction in a set of different networks that, in some cases, communicate between themselves (competing and/or collaborating) given that they might share certain goals.

By definition networks have no centre. They function with a binary logic of inclusion/exclusion. The network incorporates those nodes which are considered to be of value for the network, but if a given node ceases to perform a useful function it is abandoned and bypassed. The network rearranges itself in its new configuration. In that sense, networks are a very adaptable and flexible mode of social organisation (Castells 2000c).

That does not mean that all nodes within the network are equated in terms of their power. Some nodes might be more important than others, but they all need each other (even though no single node is essential for the network). The relevance of each node depends on its capacity to absorb more information and process it efficiently (Castells 2000c). Thus, within networks there are power struggles, where what is at stake is the management of information and knowledge, in order to become a dominant node or, in other cases, to avoid being excluded. However, given the flexibility of networks, dominant positions are provisional. They are always subject to systemic evaluation: if the dominant nodes decline in their performance, other nodes will take up their tasks and, maybe, their dominant position.

In this sense, global policy space is the site of a complex array of collaboration and competition between different actors. So, for example, international agencies have a long history of collaboration among themselves. However, competition, and the demarcation of geographical and intellectual territories also play a significant part in

the shaping of networks of international agencies dealing with education (Jones and Coleman 2005).

Multilateral organisations are also increasingly collaborating with NGOs that act at the global level and are often seen as representing an emerging 'global civil society' (Mundy and Murphy 2001, 86). NGOs also collaborate and compete between themselves, and their interactions with international agencies are not always collaborative (Jones and Coleman 2005).

Also gaining power within global policy space are corporations that participate in the global educational services industry, selling 'policy solutions' to governments (Ball 2009). For example, Cambridge Education, that defines itself as a global education services company, sells 'education policy solutions' to the National Government of Thailand, provincial governments in China, several states in the US, and in Bangladesh and Cambodia, among many other places (Ball 2009). These companies also participate in complex networks of competition and collaboration. Cambridge Education claims to have worked with UNDP and the World Bank, with several NGOs, with the Department for International Development of the UK and with other corporations (Cambridge Education's website www.camb-ed.com).

Furthermore, Ball (2007, 2009) argues that the fact that these companies are acting as educational advisors to schools and local and national governments around the world (and also providing public educational services) is made possible, legitimated and supported by an array of multinational organisations and interests groups (Ball 2009). The World Bank, the OECD, and pro-market foundations such as the Fraser Institute, the Templeton Foundation, Cato Institute, Friedman Foundation, are among the organisations that provide this support and legitimation (*ibid.*).

Many more examples could be added of other types of institutions and individuals that participate in these global networks which seek to influence education policy in territorially bound educational systems.

Nevertheless the examples above are enough to illustrate how the global policy space in education has become a complex space of collaboration and competition in which a number of diverse organisations and individuals connect themselves in networks based on specific projects, and switch to another network as soon as the project is finished. This allows for simultaneous collaborations and competition between different actors which aim at influencing education policy in different parts of the globe.

These organisations and individuals might have different ideologies, objectives, and methodologies, and therefore they produce and reproduce different discourses about how to improve education. However, it is suggested in this article that the politics and structural attributes of global space of education policy also affect the way in which these organisations relate to, produce and transform educational discourse.

Most of the literature on global education policy tends to associate globalisation and global networks with neoliberalism and the promotion of pro-market reforms (Robertson and Dale 2006; Ball 2007), given that the current global infrastructure has developed in parallel with the diffusion of neoliberal ideologies since the 1980s and 1990s, and that the global space of flows is usually linked with the dominant functions of society.

However, the global space of flows is not only occupied by a small global elite that promotes neoliberal policies. As access to the technological infrastructure that allows for dislocated interaction is expanded, the logic of the space of flows is transformed, making it a contested, plural and diversified space (Castells 2000b).

An example, in terms of networks that advocate education policy solutions, is Education International. This global network of teacher unions has 401 member organisations operating in 172 countries and territories. The overall rhetoric of Education International stresses the protection and promotion of public free education and equality of opportunity, and it usually takes an anti-neoliberal stance. This is no surprise given that teacher unions in many parts of the world have opposed neoliberal reforms. However, what comes as a surprise is that the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank (considered to be the epitome of pro-market reforms) are listed among the global partners of the organisation (Education International's website www.ei-ie.org).

This type of linkages suggests that politics in the space of flows is not so much defined by ideological principles. It is not a space occupied by neoliberal elites that interact in order to maintain their privileged position on one side and grassroots defensive social movements that cooperate to resist domination on the other. It is a complex array of diverse networks of cooperation, competition, alliances and disputes. An ally in a specific project can be a competitor or an 'enemy' in the next one. I am not suggesting that politics within the space of flows are not influenced by ideology at all. But it seems as though it is not the main factor in defining the possibility of collaboration or competition.

It is here suggested that performativity (Lyotard 1984) is a fundamental (albeit not the only) factor affecting politics in the global policy space of education. The principle of performativity implies a logic of input/output in which the final objective is to optimise the performance of a given social system. The pervasion of this principle through social relations implies a certain level of terror expressed in the phrase 'be operational (that is, commensurable) or disappear' (Lyotard 1984, xxiv). So, institutions that participate in the global policy space of education need to perform and make that performance visible in order to gain power and, in some cases, to survive. Their performance is evaluated in terms of the scope of their influence.

Thus, if the principle of performativity pervades and shapes politics in the global policy space of education, institutions and individuals who occupy this space will decide whether to collaborate and/or compete with other institutions or individuals depending on how much the network can help them improve their performance/influence. This could (partly) explain the apparent ideological and political contradictions in terms of collaborations and competitions in global space. Pragmatism seems to be more influential than ideology.

The attributes and politics of the global policy space of education influence the type of discourses produced and reproduced in this space. If global networks that advocate policy solutions are aimed at influencing education policy in as many states as possible (sometimes within a given scope, sometimes universally), the discourses that they produce have to be malleable and adaptable so as to be able to be acceptable and applicable in very different contexts. At the same time, these discourses need to have certain stability in their image in order to gain and retain certain aura of authority and power (Harvey 1989). Thus, discourse produced and reproduced in the global policy space of education requires a sophisticated elaboration that would allow for collaboration between organisations with different ideologies in its advocacy. In addition, these discourses often combine incongruent statements in the search for acceptability in different cultural, ideological, socio-economic and political contexts.

Another characteristic of global policy discourse is that it is abstracted from historical experience. As Castells (2000c, 22) suggests, in the space of flows symbols coexist without reference to experience and therefore:

Culture becomes the culture of real virtuality. It takes the form of an interactive network in the electronic hypertext, mixing everything, and voiding the meaning of any specific message out of this context ... Thus, because there are few common codes, there is systemic misunderstanding. However there is one common language, the language of the hypertext... But these codes are formal, voided of specific meaning. Their only shared meaning is to be a node, or a blip, in the network of communication flows. Their communicative power comes from their capacity to be interpreted and re-arranged in a multi-vocality of meanings, depending on the receiver, and on the interactor. Any assigned meaning becomes instantly obsolete, reprocessed by a myriad of different views and alternative codes.

This type of abstract global policy discourse includes certain definitions of how a person should be educated for current times (many times referred to as 'the information age'). Students need to be prepared for a working life in which they will have to handle complex technologies and to demonstrate creativity, innovation and adaptability. In addition, the speed at which new knowledge is created and the 'fact' that technologies will permanently, and rapidly, evolve denote the need for a system of lifelong learning. In order to become lifelong learners it is fundamental that children receive a high-quality basic education so that they can acquire a set of core skills that will permit them to learn throughout their lives. Thus, schools should concentrate on transmitting basic general competencies such as communication skills, creativity, flexibility, adaptability, learning to learn, the ability to work in groups and to solve problems (Beech 2006).

Although not all networks and organisations within the global policy space promote the same educated identity, and the above is an example based mainly on the discourse of UNESCO, the World Bank and OECD (*ibid.*), there are certain principles that have become 'common sense' and are overall present in most global policy discourses, even if they are justified from different ideological stand-points.

Two of these principles are the idea that school-knowledge should be defined in terms of 'the development of competencies'; and the notion that students should be educated to 'respect diversity'. These postulates will be used to exemplify how educational discourse is transformed in each of the contexts considered in this article.

Overall, the idea that school knowledge should be defined in terms of the development of competencies implies a critique of what is normally referred to as 'traditional school knowledge'.

Teaching traditional curricula was in many respects a relatively simple matter: to caricature slightly, the teacher possessed a certain amount of knowledge (mostly factual information) which had to be learnt and reproduced by the pupils. The teacher's task was to present the information in manageable packages, the pupils memorised the information, and after an interval the teacher tested the pupil's recall. Correct and incorrect answers could easily be identified and pupils given a mark without difficulty (OECD 1990, 100–101)

In contrast, the notion of competencies involves the active participation of students that should develop the ability to 'act upon knowledge', albeit not in the same way as in the 'industrial age' (UNESCO 1996). Competencies are usually associated with the shift from Taylorism to Toyotism, and from routine physical work to more

complex tasks that require intellectual and interpersonal skills which define a 'competent' worker (*ibid.*; De Ketele 2008). The origins of the use of the term 'competencies' to define school knowledge is overall associated with economic globalisation and the search for efficiency among corporations that, allegedly, could not find in the market the type of workers that post-Fordist labour organisation required (De Ketele 2008).

Thus, it is accepted in the literature that the use of the notion of 'competencies' in educational discourse comes from the world of work and vocational training, and that it has become widespread in education since the Second World War. However, once the concept is taken up in global policy discourse the exact location in time and space of the particular historical events that originated its use is blurred, and the concept loses its specific meaning. In this way, the idea that schools should be aimed at the 'development of competencies' becomes an abstract and malleable signifier that, as will be shown in the next sections, can be interpreted and acted upon in very different ways, depending on the context of reception.

Another example of this type of global policy discourse is the widely used slogan that promotes students being educated to 'respect diversity'. This idea has gained much visibility in education policy discourses in recent decades. It is being promoted by institutions with different ideologies, such as the World Bank, OECD, UNESCO, UNICEF, and Education International, among many others. The idea has also been taken up, at the level of official rhetoric, by many (if not most) educational systems – even by many educational systems that historically had cultural homogeneity as one of their main goals (Gvirtz and Beech 2008).

The origins of this idea can be associated with a change in western political philosophies in which the search for cultural homogeneity within the boundaries of a given nation state was displaced by the idea that cultural diversity is a positive value for society. This is linked to the emergence of post-modernism and the weakening of the grand narratives that legitimate a reading of cultural space defined in terms of the geopolitical borders of nation states (Lyotard 1984). Social movements in different parts of the world have actively challenged established narratives, criticising them for being biased in terms of class, gender, ethnicity and culture, and have fought for the representation of alternative identities in their societies.

So, the origins of the idea that diversity should be respected could be linked with different and specific historical episodes and civil rights movements in different parts of the world. However, when the discourse that promotes respect for diversity is reproduced in global educational space it is recontextualised. It is not the same discourse any longer, partly because it is abstracted from place-based historical experience and, thus, from its specific meaning. Thus, in the global space of flows 'respecting diversity' becomes an abstract slogan, its meaning dependent on the interpretation of the 'receiver' that would assign a specific meaning to both the concept of 'respect' and of 'diversity', depending on the specific sociohistoric context in which the message is received. So 'respect for diversity' could be interpreted as the protection of the rights of African-Americans, of women, of religious minorities, of indigenous peoples, of immigrants, of children with special needs, and so on. As has been mentioned, this type of slogan provides a stable image to global policy discourse that can be very appealing to governments with different ideological stances, acting in different types of contexts, since the slogan can be translated into very different policies and practices, depending on the interpretation, ideology and political objectives of the receiver.

Thus, it has been argued that educational discourse is transformed in the global policy space of education into a discourse that combines in an elaborate way certain stability with malleability and adaptability that allow for its persuasive imaging and its acceptability in very different contexts. This discourse is abstracted from place-based historical experience, and thus its postulates are stripped of their specific meaning and they become a kind of 'floating signifier' that can be interpreted and rearranged in a multiplicity of diverse meanings, depending on the context of reception. The communicative power of these discourses resides in this complex combination between stability and malleability, and between discursive limitations and reinterpretation.

This does not imply that the discourses reproduced by the different types of actors that participate from this global space are the same. International agencies, corporations, regional organisations, and universities have their own logic which affects the type of discourses that they produce (Beech forthcoming). What is being suggested in this article is that the politics and structural attributes of the global policy space of education also influence the way in which these organisations relate to and transform the educational discourses that they produce and reproduce in this global space and, thus, the type of policy possibilities that they promote. The next section will look at how this global policy discourse is transformed into education policies in the context of the state.

The transformation of global policy discourse in the state

This section will start to explore how the discourses produced and reproduced in the space of flows relate to the space of places, by analysing how the state transforms global policy discourse. Overall, the state is in a position in which it has to translate other discourses through a process of negotiation into educational policies.

It will be argued that, in this process, global policy discourse is transformed, given that the state has to specify global discourses in order to adapt them to historical experience in the territory under its realm. In addition, it will be suggested that as global policy discourse moves into the state it does not move into a vacuum; it is juxtaposed with existing discourses that define, among other things, what it means to be an educated person in that context. However, it will also be argued, that the state also needs its policy discourse to be malleable and adaptable in order to gain legitimacy and acceptability from a multiplicity of voices and stakeholders.

By definition, nation states are attached to a territory. The creation of nation states included the demarcation of precise borders that defined the limits of the power of the state over a given territory and its inhabitants (Giddens 1987). Furthermore, national educational systems during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries were aimed in most cases at the development of a national identity and a feeling of belonging that implied the coincidence of geopolitical borders with symbolic borders that divided 'us' from 'the other'.

The definition of educated identities in nation states has been historically influenced by the movement of educational ideas and practices across international borders. However, these ideas were recontextualised differently in different educational systems, resulting in specific definitions of educated identities based on a combination of supranational/global discourses and place-specific historical experience (Schriewer 2000).

Thus, as abstract global discourses move into the state they are transformed into a more specific discourse, responding to the particular social, economic, cultural and

political characteristics of the context of reception. An example of how place-based translations are essential to understand the effects of global discourses is the binary 'social inclusion/exclusion'. While Lindblad and Popkewitz (2004) argue that in Sweden and Finland 'the excluded' is the unsuccessful student, and this is generally related to deviant, low-educated and/or immigrant families, in South Africa, according to Muller (2004, 144), the idea of social inclusion/exclusion is related to race and translated as 'salvation from the dead hand of apartheid'.

In this way, policy discourses produced by the state combine global and place-specific discourses. This can result in a discourse in which different versions of what it means to be an educated person coexist. Furthermore, these meanings could even be in contradiction with each other as policy discourse combines incongruent statements of change and conservation. An illustration of this process can be seen in curricular reforms in Argentina, Brazil and Chile in the 1990s. In the new curricular documents in these countries there was a strong and explicit critique of encyclopaedism. Official rhetoric stressed the need for a shift from the transmission of facts and information, to an education based on the development of competencies (Braslavsky 1998; Berger Filho 2001; Cox 2004). However, the encyclopaedic tradition was not abandoned.

In Brazil, for example, the curricular documents for secondary education have been organised around basic competencies and abilities that students must develop like creativity, adaptability, learning to learn and problem solving (Berger Filho 2001). These are distributed in three areas: 'Languages, Codes and their Technologies', 'Natural Sciences, Mathematics and their Technologies' and 'Human Sciences and their Technologies' (Ministerio da Educação 1998). Curricular documents criticise earlier forms of secondary education in Brazil, stating that it was 'decontextualised, compartmentalised, and based on the accumulation of information' (*ibid.*). Encyclopaedic definitions of knowledge are rejected. One of the main slogans within these documents is the need for 'interdisciplinary work'; which justifies the decision to distribute school knowledge into three broad areas, rather than the typical 12–14 subjects that were offered before the reform (*ibid.*). However, the encyclopaedic culture was not completely abandoned in Brazil: although the curriculum was organised into three areas, when defining the knowledge that all Brazilian students must acquire each of these 'areas' was divided into different disciplines. Adding up the different disciplines specified within the three areas results in 14 different subjects that must be taught. Thus, two definitions of school knowledge that are in contradiction coexist in the Brazilian curriculum.

It is here suggested that this contradiction is not a specific problem of the Brazilian curriculum, but rather a characteristic of the discourse that results from the interpretation that the state makes of global policy discourse. The governing of education is not exclusively in the hands of national states. There is a division of labour of educational governance between national organisations, nation states, sub-national states, and non-governmental institutions at the global, regional, national, and local level (Dale 2005). Thus, in order to retain or regain legitimacy, the state adapts and transforms itself into a 'network state', made out of 'a complex web of power-sharing, and negotiated decision-making between international, multinational, national, regional, local, and non-governmental, political institutions' (Castells 2000c, 10).

In this sense, some of the basic characteristics of global policy discourse are also present in the state, given that it also needs a stable and at the same time malleable and adaptable discourse in order to appeal to different stakeholders. The combination of incompatible statements of change and conservation (and other contradictions), allows

for a selective use of these declarations depending on who is the receiver of the message. For example, in an analyses of the discursive construction of the 'modern teacher' in England, Maguire (2004) reveals how the concept of modernisation is deployed in such a way by the government that it combines at a rhetorical level both the need to 'keep the best of the current arrangements', and the need to 'provide for a forward looking framework' (DfEE 2001, cited in Maguire 2004, 123). This type of practice can be seen as a case of governance by 'spin' in which according to the audience and to their own political convenience, the government can decide in practice which parts of 'current arrangements' can be kept and which should be changed and how.

Spin, or impression management are 'processes of governance which attempt to manage, contain, or render invisible potential controversies that relate to policy development and implementation' (Gewirtz, Dickson and Power 2004, 98). Spin operates simultaneously at two levels. On one level it is used as a tactic to control the way in which the public (or different publics) read and interpret governmental policies. At another level, spin is not a practice external to policy; it does not only involve the way in which policies are presented to the public. It is also constitutive of policies (*ibid.*). In order to be 'spun' policy discourse needs to be shaped in such a way that it combines in an intricate way flexibility and adaptability with certain stability.

Spin is mainly performed through the mass media, which has become the principal channel of communication between the state and citizens and, consequently, politics and political campaigns are very much defined in the media.

Thus, a political message is necessarily a media message. And whenever a politically related message is conveyed through the media, it must be couched in the specific language of the media. This means television language in many cases. (Castells 2007, 241)

The language of the media requires simple messages that can be imaged in such a way that they become short slogans that can be acceptable to people with different interests and ideologies. In this sense it not surprising that the oversimplified generalisations that are offered as an educational solution for most contexts in global policy discourse become very attractive for some states.

So it has been argued in this section that as global policy discourse moves into the state it is transformed into a different discourse. This transformation is affected by (at least) four structural attributes of the state. First, it should be considered that the state (national, provincial or municipal) is attached to a territory. Therefore, abstract global discourses are transformed in the state into a more specific discourse, considering the particular characteristics of the context of reception and place-based historical experience. Secondly, it has been mentioned that as global policy discourse moves into the state it meets existing discourses that might offer different or even opposed meanings of what it means to be an educated person. In the process of negotiation involved in the production of policy discourse, the state manages these controversies by juxtaposing global discourses of change with place-specific established discourses. This tactic is also related to the third and fourth attributes that were mentioned.

The shifting into a network state and the use of spin are both linked with the need of the state to regain and retain legitimacy. These two characteristics of many contemporary states contribute to shaping the policy discourse produced in this context, since they require a discourse that combines in an elaborate way certain stability that would

allow for its persuasive imaging, with malleability and adaptability that would make it appealing to people and institutions with different ideologies and positions.

This suggests that some of the main characteristics of global policy discourse are maintained in the state. Although in the context of the state, global discourse is made more specific to territorial particularities, it is still an abstract discourse in the sense that it is not directly attached to educational practices. The abstract simplicities that dominate both global and state discourse are functional to political aims in these contexts, where contradictions and the combination of incongruent postulates can be managed. It is at the level of practice, where these abstract and sometimes contradictory simplicities have to be transformed into sustainable and interactive practices, that contradictions become apparent and are difficult to handle.

The transformation of global policy discourse into practices

In 2006 a Law of National Education was passed in Argentina. One the aims of national education policies mentioned in the Law is 'to strengthen national identity, based on respect for cultural diversity and for local particularities, open to universal values and to regional and Latin American integration' (Argentina 2006, art. 11).

This statement is a clear example of the type of discourse described in the previous section. This declaration is aligned with global discourses about 'global citizenship' and 'respect for diversity', while at the same time it retains the strong emphasis on national identity that has historically characterised the Argentine educational system. But how can this statement (or other similar postulates) be transformed into school practices? This transformation will be analysed in this section. Examples will be drawn mainly from Argentina, and other South American countries. Even though an effort will be made to deduce from these examples certain general principles on how global policy discourse is interpreted in practice, it should be noted that this section (and the whole article) is written from a specific 'perspective'.

The analysis of interviews conducted with a number of teacher educators in Argentina and in Brazil (Beech 2005), with the aim of analysing how they interpreted certain principles promoted by international agencies and adopted by national curricular reforms, illustrates some of the difficulties faced by practitioners when they try to translate the abstract simplicities of policies into interactive and sustainable practices (Ball 2000).

Some of the interviewees explicitly complained about the contradictions that they found in curricular documents:

[Official discourse] mixes different theoretical orientations. Thus, there are parts of these documents in which we can find old demands of teachers ... mixed with other ideas that from my point of view should be fought against.

[Official texts] have made an attempt to appropriate many discourses ... This sometimes turns into an epistemological salad, because there are ideas which are irreconcilable. My second impression is that this discourse that includes many perspectives is being used in practice to neutralise the opposition...

Thus, the juxtaposition of incongruent statements was seen by some of the teacher educators that were interviewed as an obstacle for the possibility of translating the new curricular guidelines into practice.

Therefore, in the process of transformation of policy discourse into practice, incoherence is an obstacle and not an opportunity for political negotiation. With very few exceptions, schools and other practice-based educational institutions are attached to a place. Most of the activities and interactions within a school are place-based. Thus, practitioners have to localise (global) policy discourse to make it more specific to the particular context in which they teach. As has been mentioned, the state also makes global policy discourse more specific to historical experience in the territory under its realm. However, the difference is that at the level of the school, discourses need to be localised and also translated into practices which require certain consistency.

The way in which interviewees in Argentina and Brazil interpreted the notion that school knowledge should be defined in terms of 'competencies' was illustrative of other ways in which global policy discourse is transformed at the level of practice, as it interacts with existing discourses in the contexts of reception. As has been mentioned, reforms in the 1990s in these countries broke with the existing encyclopaedic tradition, promoting for the first time in official discourse the notion of competencies.

Most of the interviewees acknowledged that they were discussing the notion of competencies in their lessons. However, when asked to define the meaning of the concept and the way in which it could and should be translated into practice, it was evident that there were very different interpretations among them. Furthermore, some of them had serious difficulties in providing a coherent definition, and even acknowledged that they did not know what the concept meant. Others reinterpreted the notion of 'competencies' within categories that were available to them (behavioural objectives, the objectives of Bloom, technical rationality of the 1960s). In other cases, interviewees interpreted the new curricular regulation as a legitimisation of their existing practices. Consequently, they felt that there was no need for them to adapt their practices to the new official discourse. They rather felt that the new official discourse could be adapted to describe their existing practices.

The different interpretations that the concept of competencies has been given, suggest that even though the appropriation of the notion of competencies from global policy discourses created the conditions of possibility for certain discursive limitations that demarcate the pre-established terrain in which interpretations can take place, within these limitations there were very different views on this concept. The difficulties and ambiguities in defining the notion of competencies, that is in theory the basis of the new paradigm in teacher education in Argentina and Brazil, reveals the problem faced by practitioners who have to translate the postulates of global policy discourse into interactive and sustainable practices. It might not be too difficult to define a curricular document as a set of competencies that have to be developed, yet putting this kind of education into practice – defining and enacting the kind of activities that have to take place to transmit competencies – is not so easy, especially in places where school knowledge has been traditionally defined in terms of the acquisition of facts and information.

The transformation of global discourse in practice is also related to context-specific circumstances that changed the way in which these discourses are interpreted and enacted. For example, the notion of 'respect for diversity' was interpreted differently in South American countries. In Bolivia, this idea was central in the 1994 Education Reform that was the 'most comprehensive effort to date to break with the civilizatory project that made the destruction of indigenous identity one of the school's central objectives' (Luykx and Lopez 2008, 45). The reform promoted the incorporation of

indigenous languages and cultures into the curriculum, and responded to demands that indigenous leaders and organisation had been fighting for since the early twentieth century (ibid.).

Interestingly, in Bolivia ‘respect for diversity’ was given a general approach, in the sense that the incorporation of indigenous languages and cultures was defined as being essential for the education of every child, independently of his or her ethnic origins. Nevertheless, this shift in official discourse was not easily translated into practice, and ‘entrenched racism, sexism, and linguistic discrimination persisted at all levels of the system’ (Luykx and Lopez 2008, 45).

Another notable characteristic of the Bolivian case is that ‘respect for diversity’ has provided strong discursive support to the struggles of the *Aymara* and *Quechua* against the privileges of the white and *mestizo* [mixed race] political elites, but indigenous peoples are far from being a minority in Bolivia. According to the last census, in Bolivia 50% of the population self-identify as indigenous (Luykx and Lopez 2008). Thus, a principle that is generally defined in terms of the cultural recognition of minorities has been used in Bolivia to defend the rights of half of the population from the oppression of the other half.

In Argentina, the discourse on ‘respect for diversity’ was also overall interpreted in terms of the rights of indigenous people – albeit in a very different way, partly because in this country indigenous people are a small minority that has been almost invisible in the narratives that historically legitimated national identity. Both in Argentina and in Brazil national narratives describe their people as *crisol de razas* [an ethnic melting pot]. However, while in Brazilian narratives the ethnic mixture includes whites, indigenous peoples and Afro-Brazilians, in Argentina this mixture includes only Europeans (Grimson 2006). Popular images in Argentina sustain that ‘Argentiniens descend from boats’; a statement that is based on the idea that they do not have any indigenous blood. However, the invisibility of indigenous ethnicities in Argentina is a discursive construction that is not based on demographic data, since Argentina has a higher proportion of indigenous people than Brazil (ibid.).

The movement of the notion of ‘respect for diversity’ into Argentine political discourse contributed to a greater visibility of the indigenous peoples and their claims for cultural recognition. Since the 1990s, in Argentine policy discourse in education there is a strong rhetoric about the recognition of indigenous cultures. However, this discursive emphasis on cultural recognition was translated into a few projects aimed at introducing intercultural bilingual education for the indigenous peoples, and at improving the material conditions in which these communities live and study (Cippoloni 2004). The recognition of indigenous cultures did not permeate significantly the whole educational system. On the contrary, respect for diversity was interpreted as a local problem that needs to be tackled only when (a special kind of) ‘diversity’ is present.

This localised approach to ‘diversity’ implies different interpretations of this concept in different parts of Argentina. In the suburbs of the City of Buenos Aires, where *villas miseria* [shanty towns] exist side by side with rich residential areas, claims for recognition were in many cases muddled up with the problem of redistribution. In contexts of increasing and extreme poverty, what many middle-class school teachers see as ‘diversity’ in their schools is the degrading social, economic and cultural situation of their students and their families (Dussel and Southwell 2004). In many cases, when asked to give examples of the kind of diversity that they find in their schools, educators from Buenos Aires refer to terrible stories of misery and

socio-economic exclusion (*ibid.*). Given this association, the slogan of 'respect for diversity' is often translated into 'respect for poverty'; an interpretation that can have perverse effects in practice.

These examples about how 'respect for diversity' was interpreted differently in Bolivia and in different parts of Argentina suggests that global policy discourse is transformed at the level of practice in such a way that the practical effects of its localisation depend on the characteristics of the context of reception.

Thus, certain principles on how global policy discourse is transformed in practice can be deduced from the examples presented in this section. The first principle is that the abstract and sometimes incoherent global policy discourses have to be translated into local-specific practices that have to respond to the particularity of the context, and require certain consistency. Practitioners have to assign a specific meaning to the postulates of global discourse, interpreting and rearranging its statements in order to provide certain coherence to their practices.

The second principle is that practitioners interpret and reorganise global discourses on the basis of the meanings that are available to them through place-specific established discourses in a given context. Finally, a third principle suggests that place-specific material circumstances also affect the type of interpretations that practitioners make of global policy discourses.

Concluding remarks

In this article I have tried to suggest that policy spaces in education have changed. Educational governance is defined through a complex array of interactions between global networks, states, corporations, non-governmental organisations, educational institutions, families, and many other social actors that contribute to define the type of educated identity that is promoted in schools.

Understanding these interactions implies revising established definitions of social space. The distinction between a space of places and a space of flows has been a useful analytical tool with which to make sense of the new geographies of power/knowledge in education. The way in which education is thought about is increasingly defined in the space of flows. On the other hand, as access to technological infrastructure is extended, many more social actors can participate in this space. Nevertheless, the dominant functions of society still predominate in the space of flows, in which many of the principles that define educated identities are decided. However, such principles are stated in such a way that they are attractive for place-based policy-makers, but they also leave room for very different interpretations and enactments in the space of places, where most educational practices take place.

Thus, understanding the transformation of discourses as they move from the space of flows into the space of places is one of the most important and difficult challenges for comparative education. It is through these transformations that the actual educated identities promoted in place-based policies and institutions can be construed. In that sense, this article has opened up some ideas, but this is only a stage of a long and challenging collective intellectual journey.

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